

# Hocus Focus

31 cameras are all it takes for a perfect picture of the digital camera scenario in India

**T**he traditional film-based Single Lens Reflex (SLR) camera has always enjoyed an upper hand over digital cameras. Be it an amateur or a seasoned professional, the learning curve always starts with an SLR camera, rather than a digital one. Quite obviously, the reason behind this is the price. But then why are the manufacturers still raving and ranting about the megapixel digital camera when the world seems to be happy, clicking away with the trusty, albeit bulkier, old SLRs. So is the world really ready to chuck them and adopt their digital counterparts?

The prime advantage of a digital camera (or a digicam, as it is popularly known), is the manner and efficiency in which it lets you get classy photos. You don't need to load blocky film rolls into dull dark compartments, dole out cash to have them developed, and some more cash to get them printed. All you have to do is focus, click and then transfer the images onto a PC, or get them printed right away! Furthermore, since the images are in the digital format, you can make copies of them as per your convenience, or send and share them across the world without spending a broken penny. It has to be granted that SLR cameras provide unmatched image quality that cannot be surpassed by electronic sensors, but with the recent advancements in CCD sensor technology and image processing algorithms, digicams are on their way to wiping out any differences in that aspect of photography. Already, high-end professional digicams offer image quality that is on par with their film-based counterparts.

And the weather isn't much different in the low-end and mid-range digicam country either. Though they aren't as abundant in advanced features, as their city cousins, the professional digicams, they still manage to cramp in an assortment of some of the best features boasted by the latter. But are they selling? Well, in the last couple of years, the acceptance of digital cameras has increased tremendously. Currently the digicam market is growing at a rate of 75 per cent per year—an evident enough testimony to the fact the popularity of these pocket rockets is growing, and that even seasoned professionals are slowly, but surely, going digital. And like the trend of every technology shows, such demand only means (or so we hope), that the prices will drop further, making it quite possible that we'll consider buying a digicam as often as we think of upgrading our PC configuration.

The Indian market seems to be gearing for such a scenario, with ample choice of models for every budget and function-oriented enthusiast. We tested 32 cameras, divided into the categories of Toycams, Mid-range and Low-end cameras. And to stress our point, we, also, consulted a leading professional in the stream of photo-journalism who shoots using only digicams. ■

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